which, he said, recorded that ‘Ashoka-raja with a firm principle of faith has thrice bestowed Jambudvipa as a religious offering on Buddha, the Dharma, and the assembly, and thrice he has redeemed it with his jewels and treasure; and this is the record thereof.’[5] Since no Ashokan pillar that we know has such an inscription on it, this was possibly a story circulating around the epigraph that Xuanzang gathered from local people.[6]

Legend in fact is more the staple of the narrative than measurable accuracy: in the way he describes it, Ashoka’s imprint on Pataliputra’s landscape was practically predetermined since the Buddha himself had prophesied it as a city of the future. This happened when the Buddha, on his last journey towards Kushinagara, looked back in farewell at Magadha, and, impressing his feet upon the stone on which he stood, said to his companion-disciple Ananda: ‘a hundred years hence there shall be a King Asoka; he shall build here his capital and establish his court, and he shall protect the three treasures and command the genii.’ If Ashoka’s destiny as emperor of India had been predicted by the Buddha in the *Ashokavadana*, here the sage is invoked as having prophesied, and thereby obliquely blessed, the creation by Ashoka of his royal capital.

Why Xuanzang’s account of Pataliputra portrayed it primarily as Ashoka’s city may have to do with what the pilgrim imbibed from its local antiquarians and the derelict relics that the populace had, by then, come to associate with the legends around the Buddhist emperor. His familiarity with Chinese versions of many of these, written several centuries before his time, may well have predisposed him to seek confirmation of their *in situ* authenticity.[7] The real Pataliputra, though, was very different from the remembered city.

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Pataliputra was, in a manner of speaking, the progeny of the Ganga, having been seeded at the topographical point where people and goods moved